



Same Balance, New Argument

Structured Handovers for a Babysitting Co-op’s Point Ledger

Iben Chikere · Anneke Tolan — School of Emergent Priorities

Background

Babysitting co-ops keep a running point ledger to make reciprocal childminding feel fair, but the ledger-keeper role itself changes hands every year or two. Little is known about what a new keeper actually inherits, or whether writing the handover down changes what gets disputed.

Aims

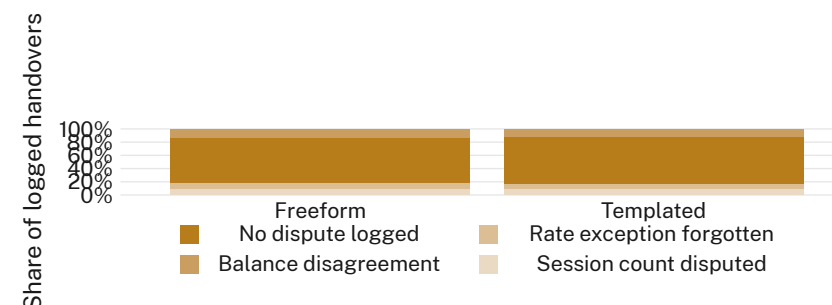
- Test whether a structured handover template reduces point-balance disputes after a ledger-keeper handover.
- Compare dispute rate and dispute type between templated and freeform handovers.
- Track whether informal side-arrangements survive the handover regardless of format.

Methods

- n = 41 babysitting co-ops recruited via parenting-network classifieds; one ledger-keeper handover each.
- Randomised assignment to a structured handover template or the outgoing keeper’s own freeform explanation.
- 10-week post-handover window; disputes logged via fortnightly co-op survey; template fields pre-registered.

Results

Point-balance dispute rates did not differ meaningfully between templated and freeform handovers across the 10-week window. Side-arrangements carried forward at a comparable rate regardless of format.



Templated handovers logged a 29% dispute rate versus 31% for freeform across 41 co-ops (Mar–May 2026) — not distinguishable from chance.

Discussion & conclusions

A template did not change what got disputed once the ledger changed hands. Side-arrangements travelled just as reliably either way — the friction sits in interpretation, not information transfer. Next: a witnessed handover, not a better-written one.

References

1. Starmer, A. J., Spector, N. D., Srivastava, R., et al. (2014). Changes in Medical Errors after Implementation of a Handoff Program. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 371(19), 1803–1812. doi:10.1056/NEJMs1405556
2. Haynes, A. B., Weiser, T. G., Berry, W. R., et al. (2009). A Surgical Safety Checklist to Reduce Morbidity and Mortality in a Global Population. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 360(5), 491–499. doi:10.1056/NEJMs0810119
3. Bauer, T. N., Bodner, T., Erdogan, B., et al. (2007). Newcomer Adjustment During Organizational Socialization: A Meta-Analytic Review. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 92(3), 707–721. doi:10.1037/0021-9010.92.3.707
4. Mikula, G. (1998). Division of Household Labor and Perceived Justice: A Growing Field of Research. *Social Justice Research*, 11(3), 215–241. doi:10.1023/a:1023282615718
5. Cohen, M. D., & Hilligoss, P. B. (2010). The Published Literature on Handoffs in Hospitals: Deficiencies Identified in an Extensive Review. *BMJ Quality & Safety*, 19(6), 493–497. doi:10.1136/qshc.2009.033480
6. Mensah, A., & Solheim, M. (2026). Still Assigned to Whoever Left: An Audit and Interview Study of a Share-House Chore-Roster Whiteboard Across Three Tenancy Turnovers. *Slop University*. doi:10.5555/slop.q4fe2g

De-identified ledger data only; no children named; consent obtained via each co-op’s group chat.

Office of Research Outputs · slop.university



“The new keeper inherited the ledger.
The arguments started anyway.”

Dispute rates held steady across 41 co-ops whether the handover was templated or improvised, March–May 2026.